

empirical fact.

Eliminating Unfair Influence

Let me state here that, except for the grocery-store mentality, I truly believe in the value of middleness and mediocrity—what humanist does not want to minimize the discrepancy between humans? Nothing is more repugnant than the inconsiderate ideal of the *Übermensch*! My true problem is epistemological. Reality is not Mediocristan, so we should learn to live with it.

“The Greeks Would Have Deified It”

The list of people walking around with the bell curve stuck in their heads, thanks to its Platonic purity, is incredibly long.

Sir Francis Galton, Charles Darwin’s first cousin and Erasmus Darwin’s grandson, was perhaps, along with his cousin, one of the last independent gentlemen scientists—a category that also included Lord Cavendish, Lord Kelvin, Ludwig Wittgenstein (in his own way), and to some extent, our überphilosopher Bertrand Russell. Although John Maynard Keynes was not quite in that category, his thinking epitomizes it. Galton lived in the Victorian era when heirs and persons of leisure could, among other choices, such as horseback riding or hunting, become thinkers, scientists, or (for those less gifted) politicians. There is much to be wistful about in that era: the authenticity of someone doing science for science’s sake, without direct career motivations.

Unfortunately, doing science for the love of knowledge does not necessarily mean you will head in the right direction. Upon encountering and absorbing the “normal” distribution, Galton fell in love with it. He was said to have exclaimed that if the Greeks had known about it, they would have deified it. His enthusiasm may have contributed to the prevalence of the use of the Gaussian.

Galton was blessed with no mathematical baggage, but he had a rare obsession with measurement. He did not know about the law of large numbers, but rediscovered it from the data itself. He built the quincunx, a pinball machine that shows the development of the bell curve—on which, more in a few paragraphs. True, Galton applied the bell curve to areas like genetics and heredity, in which its use was justified. But his enthusiasm helped thrust nascent statistical methods into social issues.